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San Francisco's new speed cameras to automatically issue tickets up to \$500



In an aerial view, traffic backs up on Interstate 80 in San Francisco on Nov. 27, 2024.
Justin Sullivan/Getty Images



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San Francisco's new speed cameras to automatically issue tickets
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Driving in San Francisco can be a challenge, and keeping track of all the different types of cameras scanning the city's roads makes it even more difficult. Though street cameras aren't new to San Francisco, the coming years will include more of the technology than ever before.

Some street cameras, like those deployed by the San Francisco Municipal Transportation Agency, aim to slow down speeding drivers or drivers running red

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Here are the kinds of cameras you can expect when driving in San Francisco.

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Speed cameras

Speeding drivers are the first group the SFMTA is targeting through 33 automated cameras it's installing across the city.

As of March 20, the registered owner of any vehicle going at least 11 mph over the speed limit will receive a ticket in the mail and, after a 60-day grace period, be

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The citations will also only be a civil penalty and won't result in a DMV point, according to [Assembly Bill 645](#), the 2023 law passed by the legislature that authorized the cameras and set the fine amounts. The cameras, [which will be operated by Verra Mobility](#), a transportation company based in Mesa, Arizona, won't use facial recognition in accordance with the legislation.



People crossing the street near Union Square in San Francisco.
Alexander Spatari/Getty Images

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One of the main goals of the cameras is to help eliminate severe traffic collisions and traffic deaths. In 2024, San Francisco recorded 41 traffic deaths, including 24 pedestrians, resulting in its highest traffic death rate in more than a decade.

In recent years, community members and city officials have called for safer streets, with a series of high-profile traffic deaths sparking widespread discussion. One collision involved a family of four, including a 1-year-old child and an infant, that was killed after a crash at a West Portal bus stop in March 2024, while another involved a 4-year-old pedestrian who was killed by a driver near Oracle Park nearly a year earlier.

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A campaign from SFMTA with ads and billboards launched in late January, with the goal of making the public aware of the speed camera locations.

Shannon Hake, the SFMTA's Vision Zero program manager, said in a Dec. 17 San Francisco County Transportation Authority Board meeting that the work that delayed the cameras has been resolved.

"I am very, very confident that these will be launching in March," she said.

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Traffic backs up at the Bay Bridge toll plaza in Oakland, Calif., on Aug. 24, 2022.
Justin Sullivan/Getty Images

The cameras are also coming to five other California cities, as outlined by AB 645. Besides San Francisco, you'll also find them in Los Angeles, San Jose, Oakland, Glendale and Long Beach as part of a five-year program.

Red-light cameras

Red light cameras have been in San Francisco since the 1990s, but the SFMTA is

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The cameras are activated when drivers enter the intersection after a traffic signal has turned red, SFMTA said. The vehicle is detected by a 3D traffic radar, which takes three photographs and a short video clip. Some of the cameras are also programmed to cite people who make an illegal right turn on a red light.

The photographs show two full rear views of the vehicle, a close-up of the license plate and of the driver. The citations, which range from \$100 to \$500, are sent to the vehicle owner's address within 15 days.

Automated license plate readers, surveillance

Another network of cameras that will be watching the city's roads are automatic license plate readers.

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San Francisco plans to install 400 AI-powered cameras made by the Atlanta-based company [Flock Safety](#) that are intended to help with criminal investigations. In acquiring the technology, the city joins other cities and neighborhoods throughout the Bay Area and across the state, including [Berkeley](#), [Oakland](#), [Palo Alto](#) and [San Jose](#).

At least 100 Flock Safety cameras were installed across San Francisco in June of last year, with the remaining 300 set to go up by July, [according to the San Francisco Mayor's Office](#). The [San Francisco Police Department](#) is not revealing the exact location of the cameras, but they are visible from the street, the mayor's office previously told SFGATE.

The cameras are [used to track down suspects](#) in crimes such as retail theft, carjacking, robbery and sexual assault cases. The technology is also used to detect [sideshows](#), locate victims of crimes, find missing people and identify potential terrorism threats, [according to SFPD](#).

The AI PR cameras capture license plates and that data along with the location

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Only one to two vehicles out of 1,000 activate an alert in the system, and the information is not shared with private companies. But while the cameras have helped police identify and arrest suspects, some privacy groups have argued that ALPRs are a form of surveillance and create less police accountability.

The technology was authorized by Prop E., which was passed by San Francisco voters in March 2024 and allows SFPD to use drones and other surveillance devices, including those with facial recognition.



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A different [network surveillance](#) of cameras contracted by [LiveView Technologies](#), which is based in American Fork, Utah, have also been deployed as part of SFPD's public safety efforts that Prop E. authorized. These panoramic lens cameras, which sit on 22-foot masts with floodlights and speakers for playing announcements, are used for "round-the clock" security monitoring.

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[Currently, several of the cameras](#) are operating in the Mission and Bayview neighborhoods. An additional location has been proposed at the 16th Street and Mission Street intersection, which was discussed last month in a community meeting.

This story has been updated.

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February 4, 2025 | Updated March 21, 2025 4:50 p.m.



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